

17

Defense, Endgames, and Transformations

How to survive the attack, trade into favorable structures, and use the c-file after queens disappear.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will know which exchanges help Black, which pawn weaknesses persist, and how opening advantages become endgame plans.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 097 | PAGE 4

Decode: Trading queens under attack*Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.*

LESSON 098 | PAGE 8

Play: Trading queens under attack*Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.*

LESSON 099 | PAGE 12

Decode: The c-file in queenless play*A file is a road; first identify the destination.*

LESSON 100 | PAGE 16

Play: The c-file in queenless play*A file is a road; first identify the destination.*

LESSON 101 | PAGE 20

Decode: Converting the ...e5 structure*In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.*

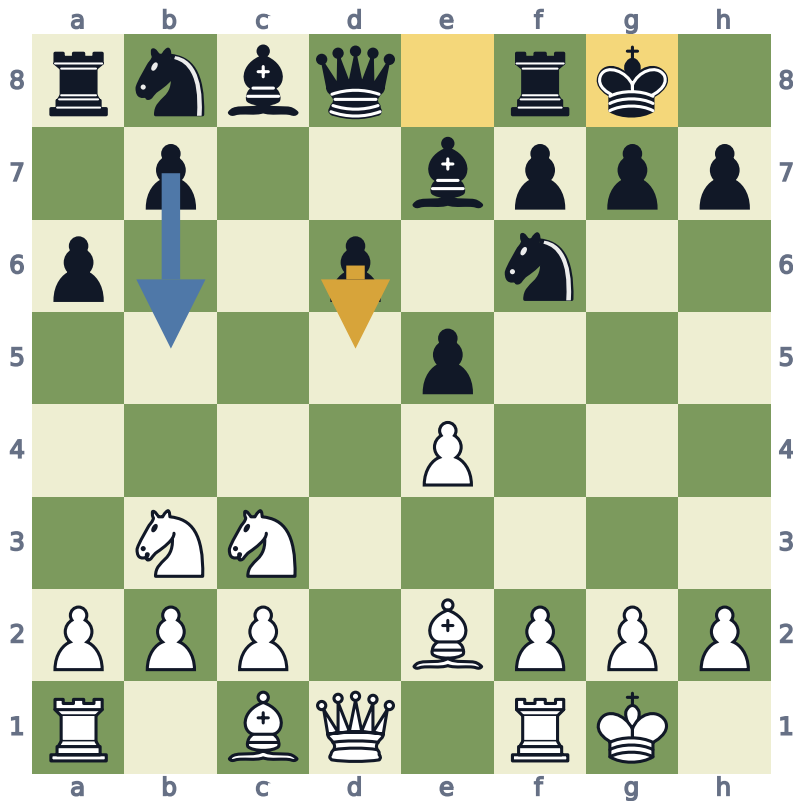
LESSON 102 | PAGE 24

Play: Converting the ...e5 structure*In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will know which exchanges help Black, which pawn weaknesses persist, and how opening advantages become endgame plans.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Trading queens under attack

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

When White's initiative depends on queen pressure, a queen trade can reveal that Black's space or bishop pair is sufficient for the endgame.

DECISION RULE

Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Offer exchanges that remove attackers while preserving active rooks and control of d5.

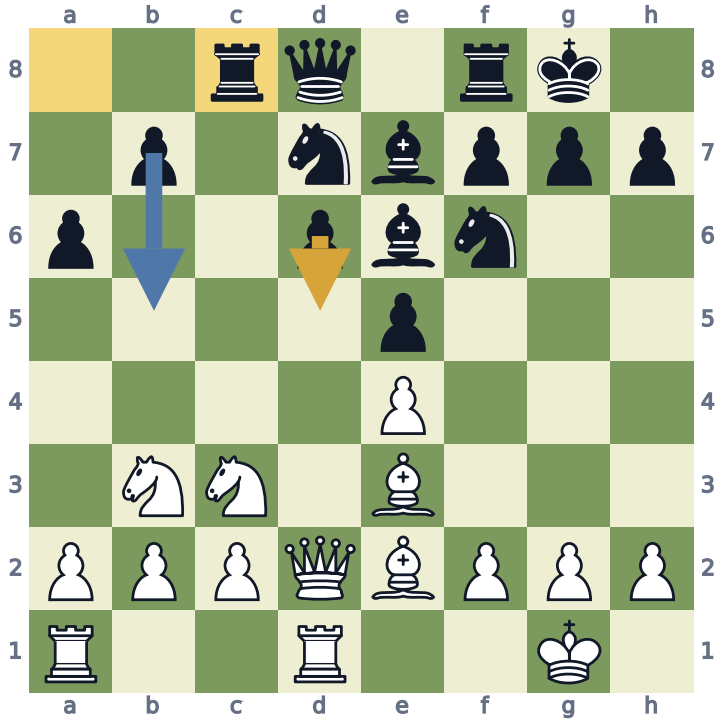
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares.

MEMORY RULE | Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

When White's initiative depends on queen pressure, a queen trade can reveal that Black's space or bishop pair is sufficient for the endgame.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Offer exchanges that remove attackers while preserving active rooks and control of d5.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares.

FAILURE MODE

Trading automatically and entering a lost pawn ending or a permanent d5 bind.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

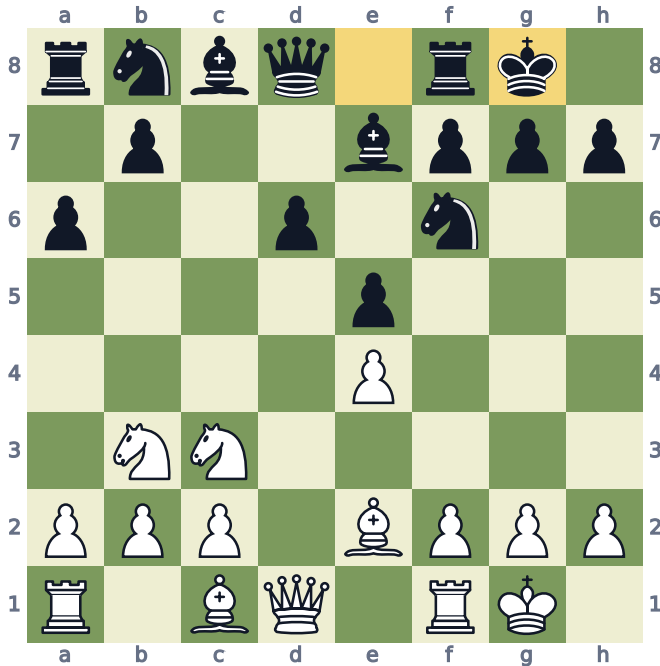
RULE | Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Nb3: White reroutes a knight to b3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When White's initiative depends on queen pressure, a queen trade can reveal that Black's space or bishop pair is sufficient for the endgame.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending? White's resistance is: White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares. The line fails as a template when: Trading automatically and entering a lost pawn ending or a permanent d5 bind.

STORE THIS | Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

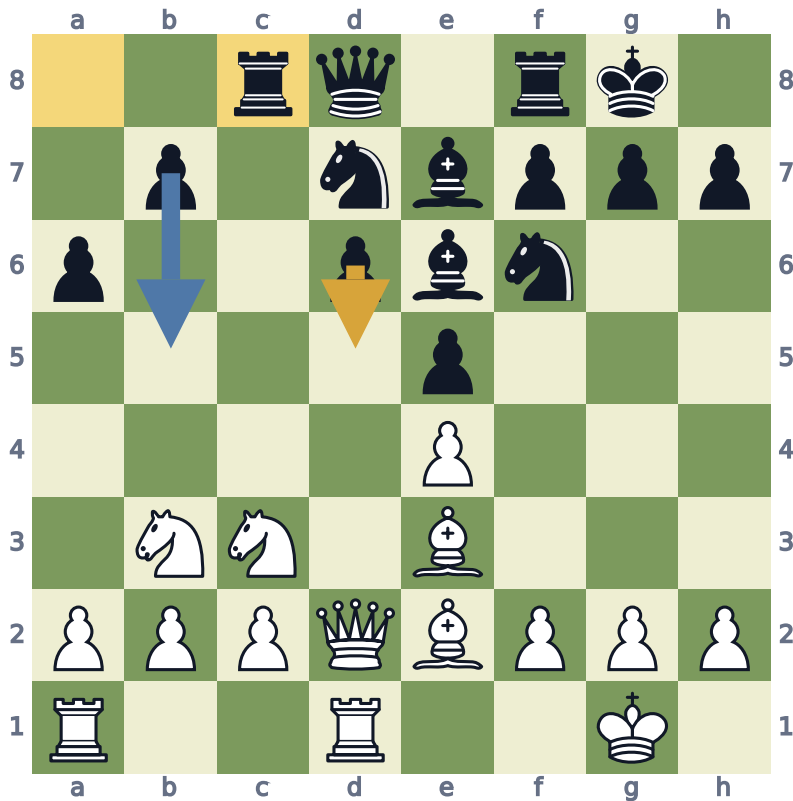
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Trading queens under attack



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When White's initiative depends on queen pressure, a queen trade can reveal that Black's space or bishop pair is sufficient for the endgame.

DECISION RULE

Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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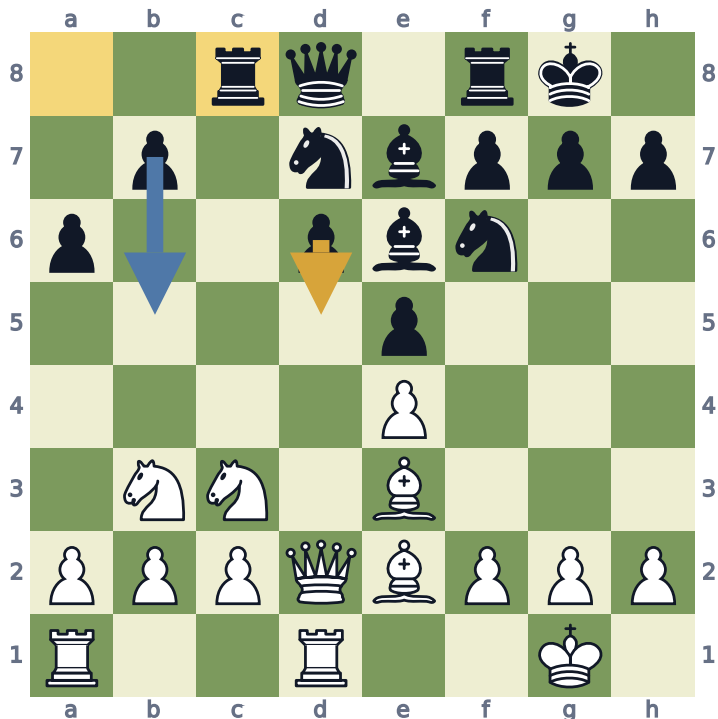
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White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares.

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares.

FAILURE MODE

Trading automatically and entering a lost pawn ending or a permanent d5 bind.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

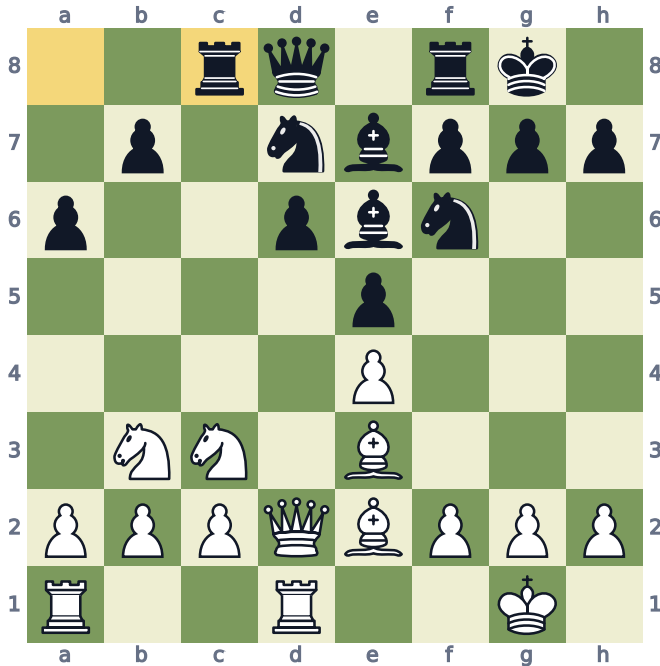
RULE | Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8



- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Rfd1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Rc8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When White's initiative depends on queen pressure, a queen trade can reveal that Black's space or bishop pair is sufficient for the endgame.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending? White's resistance is: White avoids sterile trades and tries to retain pressure on d6 and the weak squares. The line fails as a template when: Trading automatically and entering a lost pawn ending or a permanent d5 bind.

STORE THIS | Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

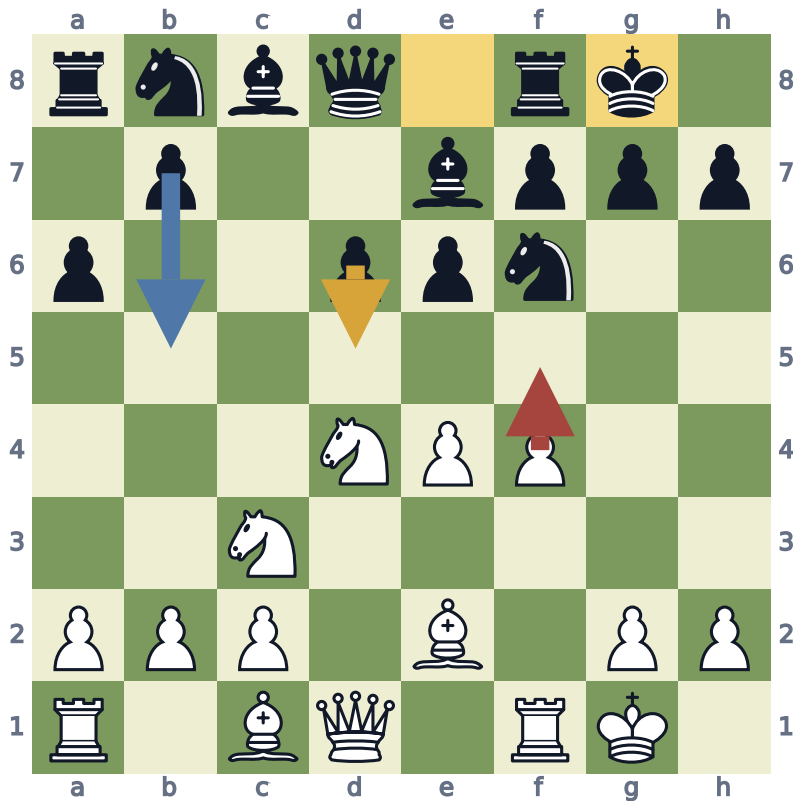
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The c-file in queenless play



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The c-file remains a durable asset after attacks fade; rooks can pressure c2 and enter through c4 or c1 if squares are controlled.

DECISION RULE

What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Contest entry squares, improve the worst piece, and create a second target before invading.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White blocks the file, activates centrally, and attacks d6 or queenside weaknesses before the rook enters.

MEMORY RULE | A file is a road; first identify the destination.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The c-file remains a durable asset after attacks fade; rooks can pressure c2 and enter through c4 or c1 if squares are controlled.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Contest entry squares, improve the worst piece, and create a second target before invading.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White blocks the file, activates centrally, and attacks d6 or queenside weaknesses before the rook enters.

FAILURE MODE

Doubling rooks on a file with no target, entry square, or supporting piece.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

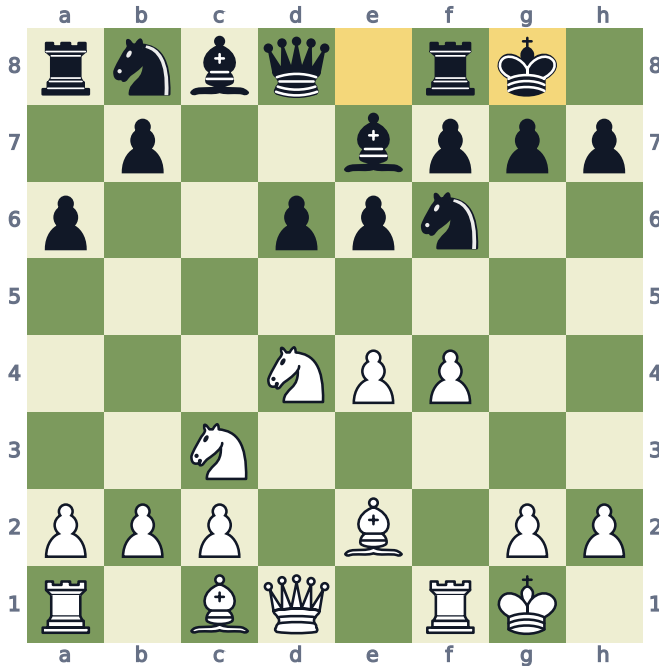
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 O-O 9. Kh1 Qc7 10. a4 Nc6 11. Be3 Re8



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The c-file remains a durable asset after attacks fade; rooks can pressure c2 and enter through c4 or c1 if squares are controlled.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first? White's resistance is: White blocks the file, activates centrally, and attacks d6 or queenside weaknesses before the rook enters. The line fails as a template when: Doubling rooks on a file with no target, entry square, or supporting piece.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The c-file remains a durable asset after attacks fade; rooks can pressure c2 and enter through c4 or c1 if squares are controlled. 2. Contest entry squares, improve the worst piece, and create a second target before invading. 3. White blocks the file, activates centrally, and attacks d6 or queenside weaknesses before the rook enters. 4. What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first? 5. Doubling rooks on a file with no target, entry square, or supporting piece.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The c-file in queenless play



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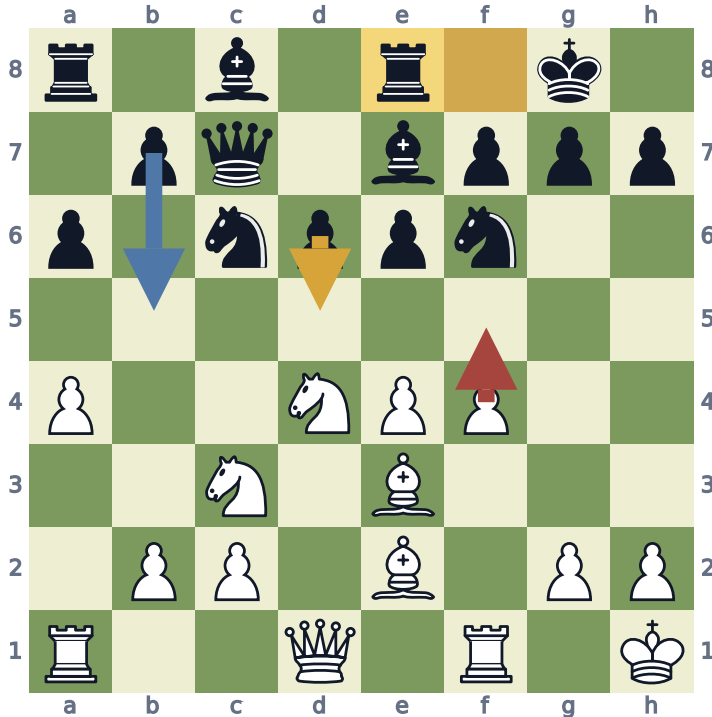
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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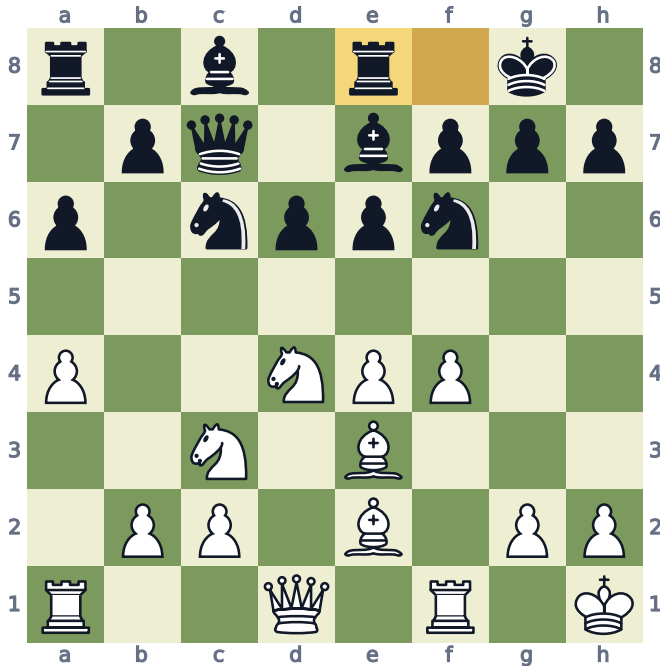
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Kh1: White improves coordination and changes the candidate set.
- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- a4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The c-file remains a durable asset after attacks fade; rooks can pressure c2 and enter through c4 or c1 if squares are controlled.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first? White's resistance is: White blocks the file, activates centrally, and attacks d6 or queenside weaknesses before the rook enters. The line fails as a template when: Doubling rooks on a file with no target, entry square, or supporting piece.

STORE THIS | A file is a road; first identify the destination.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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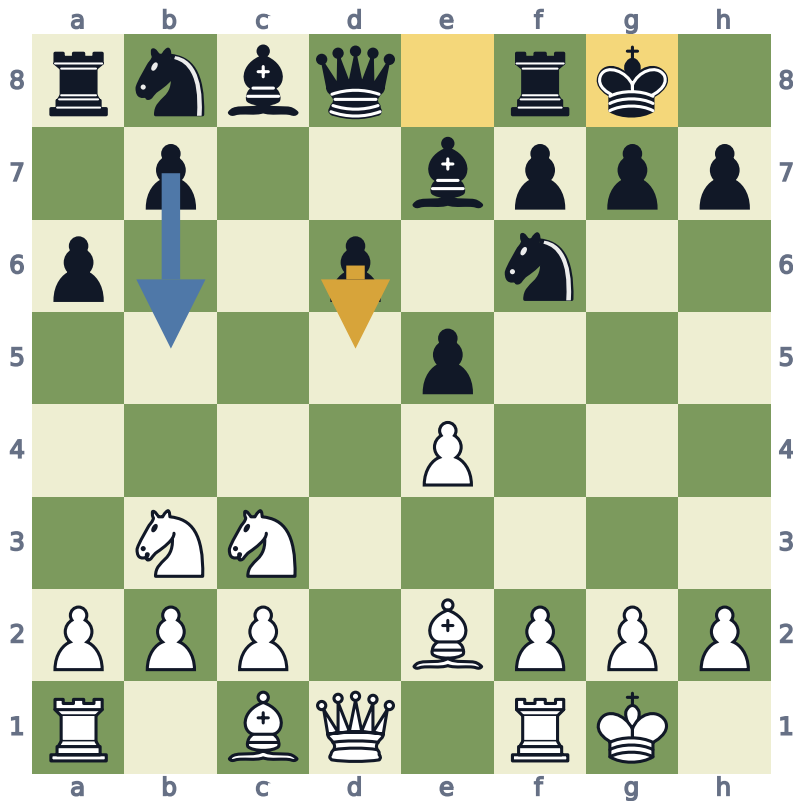
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. Kh1 Qc7 10. a4 Nc6 11. Be3 Re8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Converting the ...e5 structure

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

The d6 pawn and d5 hole can survive into the endgame, so activity and timely piece exchanges must compensate for structural defects.

DECISION RULE

Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Control d5, activate rooks, and exchange the white knight that can occupy the outpost.

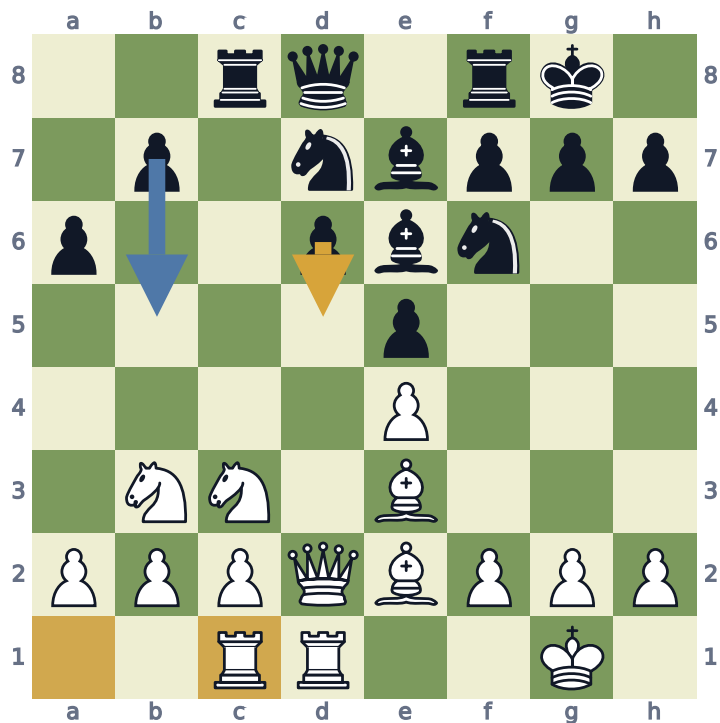
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White fixes d6, installs a knight on d5, and trades defenders to create a long-term squeeze.

MEMORY RULE | In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The d6 pawn and d5 hole can survive into the endgame, so activity and timely piece exchanges must compensate for structural defects.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Control d5, activate rooks, and exchange the white knight that can occupy the outpost.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White fixes d6, installs a knight on d5, and trades defenders to create a long-term squeeze.

FAILURE MODE

Entering an endgame because queens are gone while leaving the perfect blockading knight untouched.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

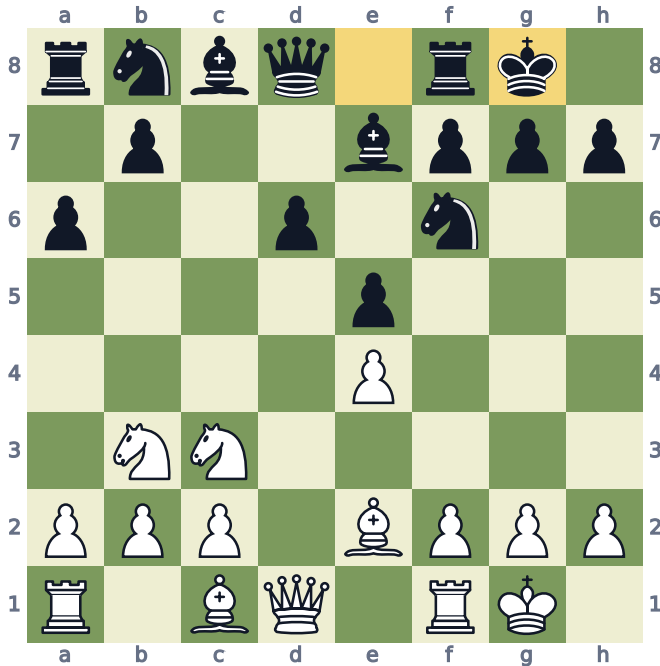
RULE | In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The d6 pawn and d5 hole can survive into the endgame, so activity and timely piece exchanges must compensate for structural defects.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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ANSWER KEY

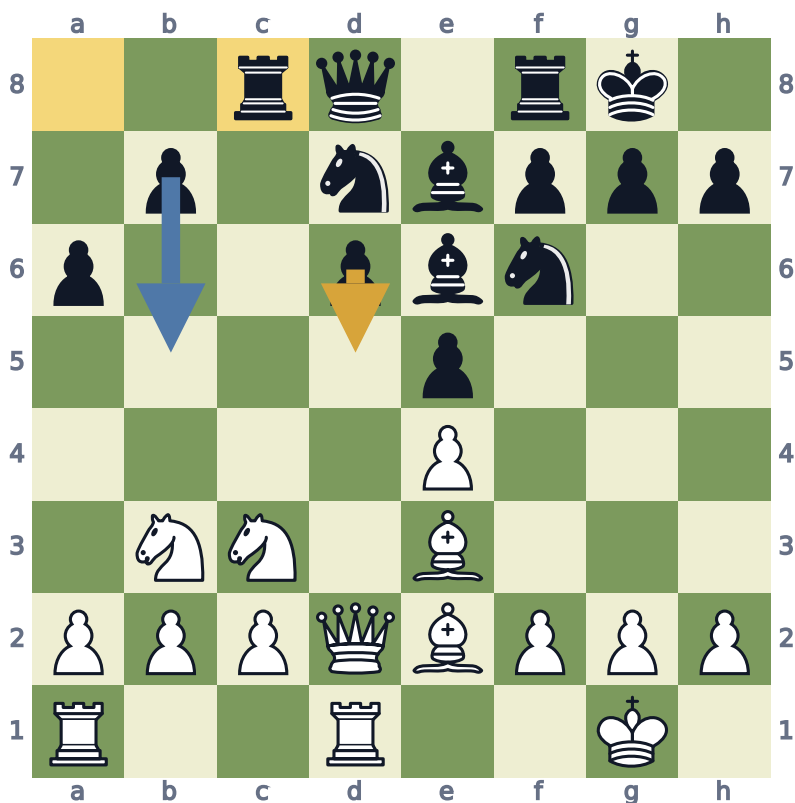
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

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PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Converting the ...e5 structure



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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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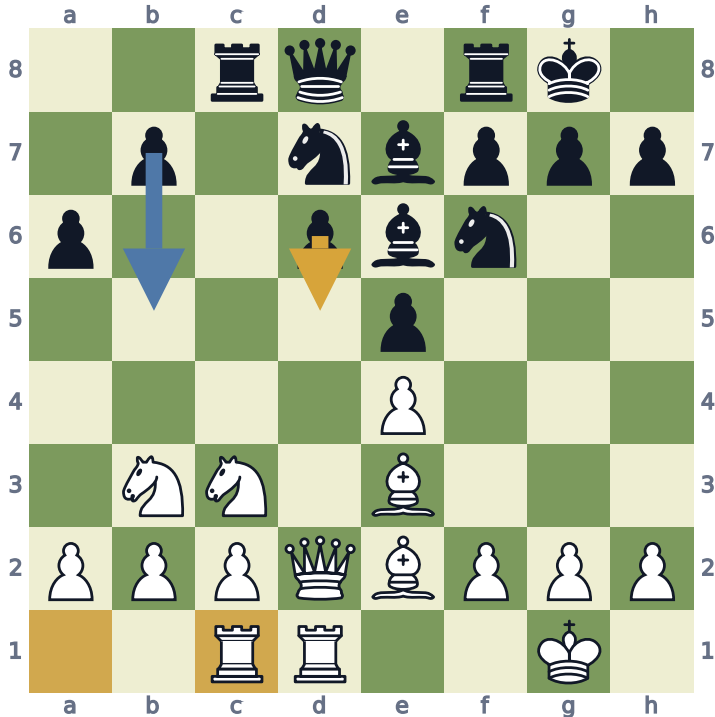
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MEMORY RULE | In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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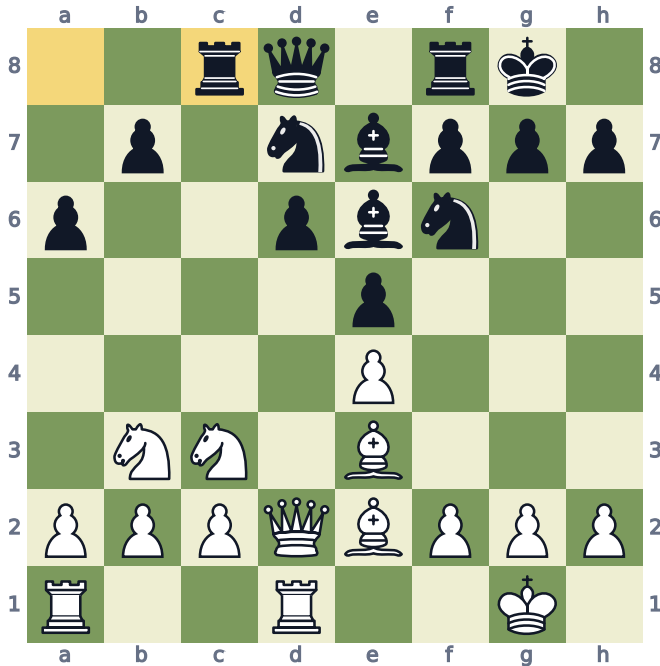
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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- Rc8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.

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The d6 pawn and d5 hole can survive into the endgame, so activity and timely piece exchanges must compensate for structural defects.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification? White's resistance is: White fixes d6, installs a knight on d5, and trades defenders to create a long-term squeeze. The line fails as a template when: Entering an endgame because queens are gone while leaving the perfect blockading knight untouched.

STORE THIS | In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The d6 pawn and d5 hole can survive into the endgame, so activity and timely piece exchanges must compensate for structural defects. 2. Control d5, activate rooks, and exchange the white knight that can occupy the outpost. 3. White fixes d6, installs a knight on d5, and trades defenders to create a long-term squeeze. 4. Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification? 5. Entering an endgame because queens are gone while leaving the perfect blockading knight untouched.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 097 Decode: Trading queens under attack

Prompt: Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending?

Recall: Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

LESSON 098 Play: Trading queens under attack

Prompt: Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending?

Recall: Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

LESSON 099 Decode: The c-file in queenless play

Prompt: What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first?

Recall: A file is a road; first identify the destination.

LESSON 100 Play: The c-file in queenless play

Prompt: What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first?

Recall: A file is a road; first identify the destination.

LESSON 101 Decode: Converting the ...e5 structure

Prompt: Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification?

Recall: In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

LESSON 102 Play: Converting the ...e5 structure

Prompt: Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification?

Recall: In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Trading queens under attack

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8

Decision: Which exchange removes attacking potential without conceding a superior minor-piece ending?

Memory: Trade the attacker, not the structure that holds your position together.

CARD 2

The c-file in queenless play

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 O-O 9. Kh1 Qc7 10. a4 Nc6 11. Be3 Re8

Decision: What is the rook's entry square, and which minor piece must control it first?

Memory: A file is a road; first identify the destination.

CARD 3

Converting the ...e5 structure

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3 Be6 10. Qd2 Nbd7 11. Rfd1 Rc8
12. Rac1

Decision: Which piece is White's ideal occupier of d5, and can Black exchange it before simplification?

Memory: In an ...e5 ending, control the outpost before counting the pawns.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
097 Decode: Trading queens under attack	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
098 Play: Trading queens under attack	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
099 Decode: The c-file in queenless play	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
100 Play: The c-file in queenless play	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
101 Decode: Converting the ...e5 structure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
102 Play: Converting the ...e5 structure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.